

THE PRIESTLY SOURCE RECOVERED INTACT?

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Who does not long for material confirmation of the Documentary Hypothesis?¹ Even disproof would be a relief. The impressive arguments marshaled on its behalf for over a century have not produced a consensus that the Priestly Source, the object of our present inquiry, ever really existed, as posited by Wellhausen and his followers. The same may be said for E and J. Many have indeed continued to uphold the now traditional image of P as an essentially continuous narrative (sometimes called P^g),² while not denying the presence of various supplements.³ Others regard P as nothing but a series of narrative and legislative supplements written into an older non-Priestly document (often

¹ By "Documentary Hypothesis" I mean the "New Documentary Hypothesis" refined and popularized by Julius Wellhausen in *Geschichte Israels*, I (Berlin, 1878), and *Die Composition des Hexateuchs und der historischen Bücher des Alten Testaments*³ (Berlin, 1899). Some competing documentary hypotheses for the origin of the Torah date back to the 17th century; see A. de Pury and T. Römer, "Le Pentateuque en question: position du problème et brève histoire de la recherche", in A. de Pury (ed.), *Le Pentateuque en question* (Geneva, 1989), pp. 15-16.

² The legal sections of P, and their relationship to the Priestly narrative, will not be considered in this study, although they will occasionally be consulted for typical P language. These may have undergone a redactional process more complex than that of P^g, possibly including a Holiness document or stratum; see most recently I. Knohl, *The Sanctuary of Silence* (Minneapolis, 1995).

³ E.g., M. Noth, *Überlieferungsgeschichte des Pentateuch* (Stuttgart, 1948), pp. 7-19; K. Elliger, "Sinn und Ursprung der priesterlichen Geschichtserzählung" (originally published 1952), in H. Gese and O. Kaiser (ed.), *Kleine Schriften zum Alten Testament* (Munich, 1966), pp. 174-98; N. Lohfink, "Die Priesterschrift und die Geschichte", *Congress Volume: Göttingen 1977*, SVT 29 (Leiden, 1978), pp. 189-225; K. Koch, "P—kein Redaktor!", VT 37 (1987), pp. 446-67; R.E. Friedman, *Who Wrote the Bible?* (New York, 1987); J. Blenkinsopp, *The Pentateuch* (London and New York, 1992); A.F. Campbell, "The Priestly Text: Redaction or Source?", in G. Braulik et al. (ed.), *Biblische Theologie und gesellschaftlicher Wandel* (Fs. N. Lohfink) (Freiburg, Basel and Vienna, 1993), pp. 32-47. Adopting a somewhat unfelicitous but useful term one encounters nowadays, I shall call this approach "Documentarian".

called JE).⁴ An ancient manuscript of P would for ever end debate on the scope and nature of the Priestly stratum, but is unlikely to surface.

Lacking such tangible proof, advocates for the Documentarian model of P rely on less direct evidence: contradictions between P and non-P,⁵ doublets between P and non-P,⁶ and the continuity of P when read without intervening non-Priestly matter.⁷

Regarding inconsistencies and repetitions, the argument runs as follows: while any writer may be allowed occasional lapses, neither a single author nor a supplementer would create a document that routinely repeated and contradicted itself. The Supplementarians consider the contradictions "corrections"—but, demand the Documentarians, why did the editor not start afresh with a new document, rather than subvert his base text, creating chaos out of order?⁸ More important: how did the editor expect his hand to be recognized? Was there not a danger that non-P would be taken as correcting P, rather than *vice versa*?⁹

⁴ Among the influential advocates of the supplement model of P are P. Volz (P. Volz and W. Rudolph, *Der Elohist als Erzähler. Ein Irrweg der Pentateuchkritik?*, BZAW 63 [Giessen, 1933], pp. 135-42); F.V. Winnett, "Reexamining the Foundations", JBL 84 (1965), pp. 1-19; F.M. Cross, *Canaanite Myth and Hebrew Epic* (Cambridge, Mass., 1973), pp. 293-325; J. Van Seters, *Abraham in History and Tradition* (New Haven, Conn., and London, 1975), pp. 279-95; R. Rendtorff, *Das überlieferungsgeschichtliche Problem des Pentateuch*, BZAW 17 (Berlin, 1977); S. Tengström, *Die Toledot-Formel und die literarische Struktur der priesterlichen Erweiterungsschicht im Pentateuch* (Lund, 1981); and E. Blum, *Studien zur Komposition des Pentateuch*, BZAW 189 (Berlin, New York, 1990), pp. 221-85. For further bibliography see Lohfink (n. 3), p. 197. Of course, these scholars, the so-called "Supplementarians", are not a school; they vary widely in their conceptions of how the Priestly stratum, and the Torah as a whole, achieved their final forms. A third approach, the "Fragmentarian", will be discussed below.

⁵ Although I believe in parallel Yahwistic and Elohist narratives combined in a single, pre-Priestly document, one can no longer speak of JE without mounting a defense of the theory. Since this is not my purpose here, I have chosen the more neutral designation "non-P".

⁶ Frequently, the doublets also entail contradiction in matters of detail. Thus, in Gen. i and ii we find two accounts of the origins of plant, human and animal life—a doublet—which disagree in the order of their creation—a contradiction. For a list of Pentateuchal doublets and contradictions see Friedman, "Torah (Pentateuch)", ABD 6, pp. 609-11.

⁷ For my own (tentative) definition of P, see appendix 1 at the end of this article.

⁸ In other words, the expected procedure for a corrector would be to change every *yahwe(h)* in Genesis to *'ēlōhīm* or *'ēl šaddāy*, simply to insert Joshua into Num. xiii-xiv, etc., etc.

⁹ For example, Supplementarians believe that the Priestly editor in Exod. vi 3 is attempting to correct the "misimpression" obtained from Genesis, that the Patriarchs knew God's name Yahweh. But traditional biblical exegesis assumes that Abraham, Isaac and Jacob did know the name Yahweh. That is, Jews and Christians have read P in the light of non-P, thwarting the editor's supposed intent. He would have done better to

Moreover, even if we accept the challenging concept of “neutralizing by addition”,¹⁰ how can we account for non-contradictory doublets? Why must we be told twice of the corruption of the antediluvian earth (Gen. vi 5, xi-xii)? Why should Noah be twice commanded to enter the ark (Gen. vi 18, vii 1), and why must he do so twice (Gen. vii 7, 13)? Why must we be told twice that all life perished (Gen. vii 21, 22-3)? Why should Jacob twice receive the name Israel (Gen. xxxii 29, xxxv 10)? Why must Yahweh tell Moses twice that he has heard Israel’s cry (Exod. iii 7, vi 5)? Do we need a new plague of *kinnîm* (Exod. viii 12-15) before ‘*ārōb* (Exod. viii 16-28), given their apparent synonymity (see Ps. cv 31)? Why should the spies twice describe the giants of Canaan (Num. xiii 28, 32-3)? Why are the Israelites twice condemned to die in the desert (Num. xiv 23, 28-35)? A few redundancies might be attributed to different sensibilities on the part of the supplementer, a few inconsistencies to absence of mind. A wholesale pattern of redundancy and contradiction is another matter. The Supplementarian claim, that the Priestly stratum was penned specifically to supplement and correct non-P, is *prima facie* implausible.

Documentarians, in contrast, have always touted repetition and inconsistency as strong evidence for their theory. They conclude that a final editor undertook to preserve parallel documents by combining them more or less intact, despite the unavoidable detriment to the coherence of the final product. To this inference R.N. Whybray raises a common-sense objection: is it any easier to conceive an editor creating such a muddle than an author or supplementer?¹¹ This argument is only superficially cogent. It is one thing for an editor, whether by choice (the Supplementary Hypothesis) or by necessity (the Documentary Hypothesis), to produce a redundant, self-contradictory text. It is another thing to imagine a single writer her/himself holding and setting down mutually contradictory views.¹²

change Yahweh to Elohim throughout Genesis, or simply to have written Exod. vi without v. 3, dropping the notion of God’s change of name. Similarly, in the Flood Story, P’s “correction” of non-P—two of each species enter the ark (Gen. vi 19-20, vii 9, 15)—has been neutralized by non-P (Gen. vii 2-3), and is taken to connote entry in pairs.

¹⁰ The expression was coined by S. Sandmel, “The Haggada Within Scripture”, *JBL* 80 (1961), p. 120.

¹¹ *The Making of the Pentateuch* (Sheffield, 1987), pp. 19, 50, 86, 126. See also J. Van Seters, *The Life of Moses* (Louisville, 1994), p. 102.

¹² See R.E. Friedman, *The Exile and Biblical Narrative* (Chico, California, 1981), p. 78. In fact, Whybray himself thinks the Pentateuchal author was an editor and reworker

The best explanation for the internal inconsistencies and consistencies of the Torah remains the hypothesis that sundry written¹³ traditions were incorporated into the Torah relatively unretouched.¹⁴ If we believe that these documents were many, we adhere to the Fragmentary Hypothesis. If we believe that they were few in number, we uphold a form of the Documentary Hypothesis.

To judge whether P is a collection of independent fragments sharing language and ideology, or an originally continuous source, we must turn to the third argument advanced on behalf of the independent Priestly document: narrative continuity. Documentarians maintain that the extant Priestly narrative flows quite well, with few breaks.¹⁵

This is often so, even in the analysis of R.E. Friedman.¹⁶ The parade examples are the Priestly sections of the Flood Account, the Table of Nations, the Plagues, the Crossing of the Sea, Manna, the Dispatching

of various sources. Thus he is closer to the Fragmentarian position than to the classic single-author concept of Judaism and Christianity. See the review by J.A. Emerton in *VT* 39 (1989), pp. 110-16; also W.H. Schmidt, "Elementare Erwägungen zur Quellscheidung im Pentateuch", in J.A. Emerton (ed.), *Congress Volume: Leuven 1989*, SVT 43 (Leiden, 1991), pp. 22-45.

¹³ Of course, much biblical tradition has an oral pre-history. But a story-teller dependent on diverse and diverging oral sources—e.g., a parent recounting a fairy tale—will inevitably homogenize in the new rendition, making reconstruction of sources nigh impossible. I fully agree with Gunkel, Noth and von Rad: the Torah's internal inconsistencies must first be approached by literary analysis, before one speculates about oral antecedents.

¹⁴ I would emphasize the word "relatively". The Redactor may have done some rewriting, e.g., converting command into execution and *vice versa*, to smoothe the seams between his sources. The matter deserves further study.

¹⁵ E.g., Lohfink (n. 3), esp. pp. 198-200; J.A. Emerton, "The Priestly Writer in Genesis", *JTS*, NS 39 (1988), pp. 381-400; Friedman (n. 6), p. 612; Blenkinsopp (n. 3), p. 119.

¹⁶ Because Friedman attributes to the Redactor what many others consider Priestly, e.g., the Toledoth lists and Wilderness Itineraries, the continuity of his P is sometimes impaired ([n. 12] pp. 77-80). But Friedman's analysis remains highly appealing, indeed compelling, as it does justice to the evidence for P as an independent document, while accounting for the presence of editorial matter. For this study, I follow Friedman's basic approach, though I find somewhat more R than he does. With Friedman, I see the Toledoth and itinerary notices as strategically placed by the Redactor to lend structure to the composite text (see also Cross [n. 4], pp. 301-17; Tengström [n. 4]). Their ultimate provenance is moot, however. Conceivably, the genealogies and itineraries originally belonged to P, but were shifted by the editor to accommodate the non-P text. For example, Gen. ii 4a may originally have preceded Gen. i 1, and Gen. xxxvii 2a may have preceded Gen. xxxv 23-6. Another possibility is that there were independent collections of genealogies and itineraries, such as are found in Gen. v and Num. xxxiii. For a list of the passages to be assigned to the Priestly stratum of the Pentateuch, see Appendix 1 at the end of the present article.

of the Spies and the Korah Rebellion. In these passages, P, read alone, constitutes a complete narrative.¹⁷ Indeed, for the Flood,¹⁸ the Table of Nations and the Spies, the P version is more complete than the non-P.¹⁹ Only slightly less impressive, because of its greater brevity, is the continuity of the Priestly story of Terah's family in P (Gen. xi 27b-31, xii 4b-5, xiii 6, 11b-12a):²⁰

^{xi} 27b Terah begot Abram, Nahor and Haran, and Haran begot Lot . . .
^{xi} 31 And Terah took Abram his son and Lot the son of Haran, his grandson, and Sarai his daughter-in-law, the wife of Abram his son, and they went (?) with them from Ur of the Chaldeans, going to the land of Canaan, and they came to Haran and settled there . . . ^{xii} 5 Abram took Sarai his wife and Lot his nephew and all their property they had acquired, and all the living things they had made,²¹ and they left, going to the land of Canaan. When they came to the land of Canaan, ^{xiii} 6 the land could not support them dwelling together, for their property was great, and they could not dwell together. ^{xiii} 11b So they parted one from the other.
^{xiii} 12a Abram settled in the land of Canaan, while Lot settled among the cities of the plain, camping near Sodom.²²

One might object that, without Gen. xii 1-3 (non-P), Abram's departure from Haran is unmotivated—but so is Terah's departure from Ur in the received text. In fact, reading P and non-P together produces a contradiction: is Abram's birthplace Ur or Haran?

¹⁷ At least, I and many others find it complete. Cross ([n. 4] pp. 303, 318) and Van Seters ([n. 11] pp. 103-12) remain unconvinced. Undoubtedly, judgements of completeness are subjective.

¹⁸ See Blenkinsopp (n. 3), p. 78.

¹⁹ Documentarians have traditionally attributed this fact to the Redactor's affinities with and preference for P over non-P. Blenkinsopp, however, suggests that sometimes the non-P matter is supplemental and corrective to P. To his analysis the objection raised above still applies: how was the reader expected to distinguish original text from supplement, and know which to believe?

²⁰ In all passages translated below, I shall render the Hebrew so as to maximize continuity from clause to clause. This is legitimate, so long as the translation is not more continuous than the Hebrew original. To save space, many of the quotations are abridged, as indicated by ". . . ."

²¹ The sense is uncertain. Perhaps the reference is to slaves and animals, acquired or bred.

²² I have omitted xii 4b, "Abram was seventy-five years old when he left Haran", which breaks the flow slightly. Either this is R, not P, or, more likely, the Redactor has transposed Priestly matter to smoothe the transition between non-P (Gen. xii 1-4a) and P. If so, P originally ran, "Abram took Sarai his wife and Lot his nephew . . . and they left, going to the land of Canaan, and Abram was seventy-five years old when he left Haran. When they came to the land of Canaan . . ."

The story of the marriages of Jacob and Esau (Gen. xxvi 34-5, xxvii 46, xxviii 1-9) also reads smoothly:

^{xxvi} 34 When Esau was forty years old, he took to wife Judith the daughter of Beeri the Hittite, and Basemath the daughter of Elon the Hittite. ^{xxvi} 35 They became a source of distress for Isaac and Rebekah. ^{xxvii} 46 Rebekah said to Isaac, "I loathe my life because of the daughters of the Hittite. If Jacob should take such a wife from the daughters of the Hittite, from the daughters of the land, my life would be unbearable". ^{xxviii} 1 So Isaac summoned Jacob, greeted him and commanded him, saying, "Do not take a wife from the daughters of Canaan . . ."

The Priestly account of Israel in Egypt (Exod. i 7, 13-14, ii 23b-25, vi 2-12, vii 1-13) also forms an impressively smooth narrative:

ⁱ 7 As Israel's children were fruitful and multiplied and swarmed and grew very, very numerous and populous, so that the land was full of them, ⁱ 13 the Egyptians enslaved Israel's children with severity. ⁱ 14 They embittered their lives with hard labor in mortar and bricks, and all kinds of work in the field—in short, with all their labor, with which they severely enslaved them. ⁱⁱ 23b And Israel's children were moaning from the work, and they screamed, and their plea ascended to God from the work. ⁱⁱ 24 When God heard their groan, God remembered his covenant with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. ⁱⁱ 25 When God saw Israel's children, he revealed himself to them. ²³ ^{vi} 2 God spoke to Moses and said to him, "I am Yahweh . . . ^{vi} 6c I shall take you out from under the burdens of Egypt . . ."

^{vi} 9 Moses duly spoke to Israel's children, but they did not heed Moses because of dispiritedness and hard work . . . ^{vi} 12 Moses spoke up before Yahweh, saying, "If Israel's children have not heeded me, how will Pharaoh heed me, since my lips are uncircumcised"?

^{vii} 1 Yahweh said to Moses, "See, I have made you a god to Pharaoh, and Aaron your brother will be your prophet . . ."

Somewhat less clear are cases where the now-separated Priestly passages present sequential episodes, rather than forming a continuous account. While it makes sense for Isaac's birth (Gen. xxi 1b, 2b-5) to follow its prediction in Gen. xvii,²⁴ or for Jacob's burial (Gen. l 12-13) to follow his death (Gen. xlix 33), or for Aaron's death (Num. xx 23-9) to follow his condemnation at Meribah (Num. xx 1-13),²⁵ there is room

²³ Translating after the LXX; see below.

²⁴ The intervening P matter, Gen. xix 29 (Lot's rescue), may originally have followed xiii 11b-12a (Lot's settling in Sodom) (Noth [n. 3], p. 13).

²⁵ Friedman ([n. 6] p. 612) offers another example of continuity, suggesting that the

for intervening material, such as is found in the received text.²⁶

At places one would have to call the connection between separate pieces of P only adequate, not compelling: e.g., the birth of Isaac (Gen. xxi 1b, 2b-5), followed by the death and burial of Sarah (Gen. xxiii), followed by the death of Abraham himself and the succession of Isaac (Gen. xxv 7-11a),²⁷ followed by a list of Ishmael's descendants (Gen. xxv 13-18), followed by the marriage of Isaac (Gen. xxv 20).²⁸ This may be acceptable in a schematic summary of history, but we cannot speak of clear flow. A similarly awkward transition, or lack of it, lies between Jacob's departure for Paddan-aram (Gen. xxxi 18b) and God's revelation in Gen. xxxv 9-15. And we find again a somewhat choppy sequence in the transition from Gen. xlvii 6-27, a list of Jacob's family, to Gen. xlvii 27b-28, describing their multiplication and the death of Jacob. A final example of merely adequate flow is the departure from Sinai (Num. x 14-27), preceding the dispatch of spies (Num. xiii-xiv *passim*). What happened during the interim?

While these transitions strike us as slightly abrupt, they may not have been so for the author. After all, a continuous P passage, Gen. xxxv 23-9, brusquely reports the birth of Jacob's sons (*vv.* 23-6), their return to Canaan (*v.* 27) and Isaac's death (*vv.* 28-9). Had these notices appeared separately in the composite text, we would have hesitated to claim that they had ever flowed together. This is important evidence that the Priestly Writer's sensibilities were not our own.

people's mourning in Num. xxv 6-9 does not react to the sin of Baal Peor, but rather to the death of Aaron (Num. xx 23-9). This may well be so, providing we locate Mount Hor in the vicinity of Mount Peor.

²⁶ Sequential P narratives separated by Priestly legislative or technical material belong to a special category. If P⁸ contained narrative alone (which I doubt), or was based upon an earlier narrative, then these episodes originally flowed together. For example, Exod. xxxiv 29-35 (the burning/shining of Moses' face) follows well upon Moses' entering the fiery cloud (Exod. xxiv 15b-18); Num. xx 1-13 (the abuse of Aaron's rod) follows well upon Korah's rebellion and its aftermath (Num. xvi-xvii *passim*). For my interpretations of these passages, see "The Skin of Moses' Face—Transfigured or Disfigured?" *CBQ* 49 (1987), pp. 375-86; "The Rod of Aaron and the Sin of Moses", *JBL* 107 (1988), pp. 19-26 (the analysis of the latter is identical with that of Blum [n. 4], pp. 273-4). Exploration of the relationship between P narrative and the technical material must await a future study.

²⁷ Probably R or some other later hand has supplemented Gen. xxv 9-10, to remind us of the circumstances of the purchase of Machpelah. If Gen. xxv 7-11a originally followed Gen. xxiii, such allusions would have been superfluous.

²⁸ Gen. xxv 11a, "After Abraham's death God blessed Isaac in everything", would be a more natural introduction to Gen. xxv 20, the marriage of Isaac. Perhaps, like the Edomite material in Gen. xxxvi 1-30, the list of Ishmael's sons is a supplement to P (cf. Noth [n. 3], p. 17, n. 48).

There are other points at which the transition from P to P is truly difficult, yet not impossible. For example, after the Creation (Gen. i 1-ii 3) we read immediately of the Flood (Gen. vi-ix *passim*), learning nothing of the intervening generations, save that the earth had become corrupt (Gen. vi 11-12).²⁹ There is a similarly awkward skip from the Noachic covenant (Gen. ix 8-17) to the list of Noah's descendants (Gen. x 1b). Then P leaps again to Terah. These difficulties would be solved—and others raised—by giving to P the genealogical material in Gen. v 1-28, 30-2, x 1a, xi 10-16 (see n. 16).

In Exodus, we find additional possible gaps in P. Moses appears from nowhere in Exod. vi 2.³⁰ Did he need no introduction, or is something missing?³¹ P foretells (Exod. xii 12) but never describes the death of the Egyptian first-born. Did the prophecy suffice? In the conventional analysis of the Priestly Sinai pericope, notice of Israel's arrival at Sinai (Exod. xix 1) is followed immediately by the Decalogue (Exod. xx 1-17), without any intervening narrative.³² In fact, as Supplementarians often note, P lacks any covenant ceremony at Sinai.³³ We could regard this, however, not as a difficulty, but as a key characteristic of P: more important than a covenant ritual is Yahweh's continuing presence with the people.³⁴

²⁹ Friedman orally (and tentatively) suggests another possible case of the Redactor transposing Priestly matter to enhance continuity with non-P. If we reverse Gen. vi 9b-10 and 11, the result flows from Gen. ii 1-3 as follows: "When the heaven and the earth, and all their host, were finished, on the sixth (LXX; MT seventh) day God finished his work he had done, and he desisted on the seventh day from all his work he had done. God blessed the seventh day and sanctified it, for on it he desisted from all his work, which God, making, had created. But the earth became corrupted before God, and the earth was filled with lawlessness. Noah, however (read *wěñōah), was a righteous man, perfect among his contemporaries . . ." In this rearrangement, Gen. vi 12 could follow either v. 10 or v. 11. But even leaving P in its present order, the transition between Creation and Flood is merely difficult, not impossible.

³⁰ Noted by Rendtorff (n. 4), p. 130, n. 4.

³¹ Koch (n. 3), p. 465, cites many parallels; the most famous, which Koch does not include, is Elijah (1 Kgs xvii 1), although he is given at least a geographical provenance (M. Greenberg, *Understanding Exodus* [New York, 1969], p. 148, n. 1). Koch further observes that the genealogy in Exod. vi 14-25 adequately explains who Moses is; I, however, attribute these verses to R, not P (see my forthcoming *Anchor Bible* commentary on Exodus).

³² In fact, the Decalogue is probably R's reworking of non-Priestly material. For P proper, then, we should skip from Exod. xix 1 to xxiv 15b-18: "In the third month after the departure of Israel's children from the land of Egypt, on this day, they came to the Wilderness of Sinai. And Moses ascended the mountain, and the cloud covered the mountain . . ."

³³ E.g., Cross (n. 4), pp. 295-8.

³⁴ See Blenkinsopp (n. 3), pp. 185-6. P (or H) does have the notion of a covenant

Occasionally, there are truly impossible transitions within P. For example, there are no births of Jacob and Esau between Gen. xxv 20 and xxvi 34. Immediately after Jacob's departure for Aram in Gen. xxviii 1-5, Gen. xxxi 18b notes his return.³⁵ Finding continuity in P grows especially difficult toward the end of Genesis: Jacob is living in Canaan (Gen. xxxvii 1), then Joseph is suddenly Pharaoh's servant (Gen. xli 45b-46a), then Jacob and family migrate to Egypt (Gen. xlii 6-27). Jacob's lifespan is reported in Gen. xlvii 28, then suddenly he is talking to Joseph's family (Gen. xlviii 3-6), then equally suddenly he is addressing all his sons (Gen. xlix 29-33). Taken alone, these passages would imply that P is a supplemental stratum, not an independent source. But they are a minority. A better explanation is that some of P is now missing, or that the Joseph story was not part of JE, but entered the Pentateuch through a separate process,³⁶ or that we have mistaken R for P. Overall, I find it easier to believe that we simply lack a portion of the Priestly stratum, than that an editor voluntarily introduced repetition and self-contradiction.

In the majority of cases, the now disarticulated Priestly passages, when reassembled, flow together at least adequately, often compellingly. A Supplementarian might rejoin that a series of chronological, genealogical and narrative supplements to a pre-existing narrative could itself, by sheer coincidence, form a narrative. Such an argument is to my mind far-fetched, but it cannot be rejected out of hand, especially given the occasionally fragmentary appearance of P.³⁷

We have yet to consider a final argument in favor of the Supplementarian model of P: in places P seems to allude to non-P. Thus, the corruption of the earth (Gen. vi 11-12 [P]) could refer to the Eden incident and its aftermath (Gen. ii 4b-iii 24, iv 1-26, v 29, vi 1-4 [non-P]); the prohibition of murder/fratricide (Gen. ix 5-6 [P]) could refer to Cain and Abel (Gen. iv 1-16 [non-P]); the brief notice of Isaac's marriage to Rebekah (Gen. xxv 20 [P]) could refer to the events of

at Sinai, however, as the blessings and curses of Lev. xxvi 3-45 make clear (note also the covenant of Sabbath observance in Exod. xxxi 12-17). But P nowhere narrates the establishment of this covenant.

³⁵ Reversing Priestly passages, by inserting the birth of Jacob's sons (Gen. xxxv 23-6) between Gen. xxviii 1-5 and xxxi 18b, would slightly alleviate this difficulty.

³⁶ Although the Joseph material is nowadays often dissociated from JE (e.g., D.B. Redford, *A Study of the Biblical Story of Joseph [Genesis 37-50]*, SVT 20 [Leiden, 1970]), such an analysis ignores themes connecting the Jacob and Joseph cycles, explored by R.E. Friedman, "Deception for Deception", *BibRev* 2.1 (1986), pp. 22-31, 68.

³⁷ See the honest discussion of the Supplementarian Blum (n. 4), pp. 240-2.

Gen. xxiv (non-P). Sometimes there are lexical contacts: e.g., the Israelites' *sēbālôt* "tasks/burdens" are mentioned in both P (Exod. vi 6) and non-P (Exod. i 11, ii 11, v 4, 5).

This list of apparent allusions could no doubt be considerably expanded—but to no purpose. Documentarians have ready answers. If P is based upon non-P, combining the two texts would inevitably produce apparent internal allusions. In any case, few if any of the supposed references are explicit; typically, we have shared language, rather than citation of actual events. For true cross-references, we may readily posit a secondary harmonization, whether by the Redactor or by an even later hand (e.g., the inclusion of Dathan and Abiram in Num. xvi 24, 27 in the MT, but not in the LXX).³⁸ Finally, Lohfink argues that P presupposes familiarity with non-P.³⁹ In short, any allusions between P and non-P are susceptible of various plausible explanations, and cannot alone establish the Supplementarian position.

How, then, might Supplementarians prove the likelihood of their case? Quite simply: by showing that P only rarely duplicates or contradicts non-P material, and that stitching P together rarely or never produces a coherent narrative. This is just the case for the editorial stratum of Deuteronomy-2 Kings, the existence of which, since the work of Noth, has never been doubted.⁴⁰ It is manifestly not the case for P.

Most of these points are not new. The annoying fact remains: while we can establish likelihood, we cannot prove the existence of P as an independent source without an ancient manuscript connecting its now *disiecta membra*. Even an incomplete manuscript would show that *some* document lay behind P, that the author was not simply improvising a supplement to an earlier text. While I have not located such a scroll, I shall argue that a fragment of the intact Priestly Source can be excavated out of the book of Ezekiel.

Let us consider again Exod. ii 23b-25, which in the MT reads as follows:

^{23b}Israel's children were moaning from the work, and they screamed, and their plea ascended to God from the work. ²⁴When God heard their groan, God remembered his covenant with Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. ²⁵When God saw Israel's children, God knew (*wayyēda' 'ēlōhîm*).

³⁸ See the brief comments of de Pury and Römer (n. 1), p. 71.

³⁹ Lohfink's case must be balanced against Friedman's conclusion that the Priestly Writer intended his work to supersede non-P.

⁴⁰ *Überlieferungsgeschichtliche Studien* (Halle, 1943; reprinted, Tübingen, 1957).

All source critics ascribe these verses to P, since Yahweh is called *'ēlōhîm*, and since the theme of his “remembering” (*zkr*) his covenant is paralleled in Priestly texts Gen. ix 15, 16; Exod. vi 25; Lev. xxvi 42.

There is debate, however, over the original function of Exod. ii 23b-25. If P is simply an editorial stratum, then Exod. ii 23b-25 always served its present purpose, introducing the non-Priestly Burning Bush (Exod. iii-iv). If, however, P was once an independent source (or is closely based upon an independent source), then Exod. ii 23b-25 constituted the introduction to Exod. vi 2-9, Yahweh's first revelation to Moses and Israel in Egypt. Only through editing did Exod. ii 23b-25 come to preface the Burning Bush scene. The passage is an ideal test case for the document versus supplement dilemma.

Strong arguments have been mustered on both sides. J.-L. Ska,⁴¹ basically a Supplementarian despite his attempt to straddle the fence, stresses the connections with the Burning Bush scene: Israel's cry (*z/s'q*) (Exod. ii 23 [P]; iii 7, 9 [non-P]); Yahweh seeing (Exod. ii 25 [P]; iii 7, 9 [non-P]) and hearing (Exod. ii 24 [P]; iii 7 [non-P]) Israel's suffering; evocation of the Patriarchs (Exod. ii 24 [P]; iii 6, 13, 15, 16 [non-P]); God's “knowing” (Exod. ii 25 [MT, but see below] [P]; iii 7 [non-P]).

But equally strong contacts exist with Exod. vi 2-9, the next Priestly passage:

²God spoke to Moses and said to him, “I am Yahweh. ³I appeared to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob as God Shaddai, but by my name Yahweh was not known to them. ⁴Whereas I established my covenant with them to give them the land of Canaan, the land of their sojournings, in which they sojourned, ⁵and whereas I have heard the groan of Israel's children because the Egyptians enslave them, therefore I have remembered my covenant. ⁶Say, then, to Israel's children: ‘I am Yahweh. I shall take you out from under the burdens of Egypt, and I shall remove you from their service, and I shall redeem you with an extended arm and with great judgements. ⁷I shall take you to be my people, and I shall become your god. Then you will know that I am Yahweh your god, who shall take you out from under the tasks of Egypt, ⁸and shall bring you to the land that I raised my arm (i.e., swore) to give to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. I shall give it to you as an inheritance. I am Yahweh.’”

⁹Moses duly spoke to Israel's children, but they did not heed Moses, because of dispiritedness and hard labor.

⁴¹ “Quelques remarques sur P⁸ et la dernière rédaction du Pentateuque”, *Le Pentateuque* (n. 1), pp. 119-20.

In its present context this theophany serves to reassure Moses after the debacle of Exod. v 1-vi 1, where his efforts only increased Israel's sufferings.⁴² For Supplementarians, that always was its function. Again, Ska notes ([n. 41] p. 102) various linguistic and thematic links to the preceding non-P material: the verb *hiššîl* (Exod. v 23 [non-P], vi 6 [P]); the root *'bd* (Exod. v 9, 11, 15, 16, 18, 21 [non-P], vi 6 [P]); the noun *sēbālôt* (Exod. v 4-5 [non-P], vi 6, 7 [P]); the reference to Yahweh's saving arm (Exod. vi 1 [non-P], 6 [P]); the reference to judgement (Exod. v 21 [non-P]; vi 6 [P]); above all, the theme of knowing Yahweh (Exod. v 2 [non-P]; vi 3, 7 [P]).

A Documentarian would, in rebuttal, point to the surprising lack of any mention of the first theophany at the Bush (Exod. iii-iv), or the events of Exod. v 1-vi 1: why does Moses object, "How will Pharaoh listen to me"? (Exod. vi 12), rather than, "Pharaoh, so far, has not listened to me"? The Documentarian would note that non-P and P use the theme of judgement in different ways: in Exod. v 21 (non-P) the Hebrew officers ask God to judge Moses and Aaron, while in Exod. vi 6 (P) Yahweh proclaims that he will enact judgements against Egypt. The Documentarian would ask how one could describe the Hebrew experience in Egypt, and their relationship to Yahweh, without using the noun *'ebed* "slave" and the verb *'ābad* "work, worship". And the remainder of the lexical contacts could reflect P's dependence on non-P. As we have seen, the argument from shared language is inherently inconclusive.

For Documentarians, Exod. vi 2-9 is Moses' first encounter with Yahweh in the independent Priestly Source. After all, v. 3 contains the contradiction that spawned documentary analysis in the first place: it is simply not true in the received text that God was unknown as Yahweh before Moses' time (see Gen. xv 2, etc., etc.). The transfer of the scene from the desert (Exod. iii-iv [non-P]) to Egypt bespeaks the writer's hostility to Midian.⁴³ Only when a second hand inserted Exod. vi 2-9 into its current context did it become, perforce, a scene of reassurance.⁴⁴

⁴² Greenberg (n. 31), pp. 130-6, 145-50.

⁴³ Further evidence of this animus is the change of the villainesses of Baal Peor from Moabites (Num. xxv 1 [non-P]) to a Midianite (Num. xxv 6, 14-15, 18). Also, the figure of Jethro, Moses' father-in-law and priest of Midian, is absent from P, which acknowledges only Aaronids as legitimate priests of Yahweh. See Friedman (n. 3), p. 204.

⁴⁴ An obvious question is why the Redactor did not splice P's Call of Moses into the Burning Bush (Blum [n. 4], p. 234, n. 23). To have done so would have necessitated drastic rearrangement of the text, as well as altering *šm'w* "have (not) heeded me" to **yšm'w* "will (not) heed me".

The Documentarian rather links Exod. vi 2-9 with ii 23b-25, with which it plainly shares vocabulary and themes: “remembering” (*zkr*) the “covenant” (*bērît*) with the three Patriarchs, the “hearing” of Israel’s “groan” (*na’āqā*). Moreover, as we shall see, the theme of God making himself known in all likelihood binds Exod. ii 23b-25 to vi 2-9. These are more specific connections than those between P and non-P. This would not dishearten a Supplementarian, however, who does not deny that the P stratum has a characteristic style and ideology, only that it ever stood alone.

Before considering further the original function of Exod. ii 23b-25, we must examine a textual difficulty in v. 25. The last two words in the MT, “and God knew” (*wyḏ’ ʾlhm*), appear in the LXX as “he made himself known to them” (καὶ ἐγνώσθη αὐτοῖς), as if the LXX were reading **wywḏ’ ʾlyhm*. Whichever reading is original, the other features *waw-yodh* confusion plus haplography or dittography in the first word,⁴⁵ and a metathesis of *yodh* and *he’* in the second.⁴⁶

In favor of the MT, we should note that no extant Hebrew manuscript supports the LXX; the reading **wywḏ’ ʾlyhm* may have existed only momentarily in the mind of the translator. Also in favor of the MT is its slight awkwardness (*lectio difficilior*). Feeling a difficulty, almost all translations supply an object for the verb, e.g.: “God took notice of them” (*New International Version*), “God knew their condition” (*Revised Standard Version*), “God cared for (them)” or “kept them in mind”.⁴⁷ But the MT is not so awkward as to be impossible. Greenberg ([n. 31] p. 54) finds a rough parallel in Gen. xviii 21, while Thomas ([n. 47] p. 143, n. 7) cites 1 Kgs i 11, 18; Hos. viii 4, and best of all is Blum’s comparison ([n. 4] p. 240, n. 43) with Gen. xxxv 22a, “And Israel heard”. Since *yḏ’* has covenantal overtones, one could even discern in ii 24-25 an

⁴⁵ That is, either *wyw* > *wy* or *wy* > *wyw*. On the similarity of *waw* and *yodh* in Graeco-Roman period Hebrew script see F.M. Cross, “The Development of the Jewish Scripts”, in G.E. Wright (ed.), *The Bible and the Ancient Near East* (Fs. W.F. Albright.) (Garden City, New York, 1961), pp. 133-202; E. Qimron, “*Hahabḥānā bēn wāw lēyōd bit’ūdōt midbar yēhūdā*”, *Beth Mikra* 18 (1972), pp. 102-12.

⁴⁶ The posited metathesis requires that *ʾālēhem* was spelled *plene* in the LXX *Vorlage*, as throughout Samaritan Exodus. The defective spelling *ʾlhm* is always used in MT Exodus, and is markedly preferred throughout the Torah (86 defective vs. 16 *plene*). This tendency stands in contrast to the Torah’s preference for *ʾlykm* over *ʾlkm* (21 *plene* vs. 6 defective), and *ʾlyhm* over *ʾlhm* (33 *plene* vs. 10 defective) (statistics courtesy of J. Geoghegan and “Bible for Windows”). It would seem that the MT spells *ʾālēhem* defectively to minimize confusion with *ʾlhm* “God”.

⁴⁷ The last two are the alternative renderings of D.W. Thomas, “A Note on *wayyēda’ ʾēlohīm* in Exod. II. 25”, *JTS* 49 (1948), pp. 143-4.

ABA'B' structure: God hears, God remembers his covenant, God sees, God acknowledges (*yda'*) his covenantal obligation to Israel.⁴⁸ Alternatively, we could regard *rā'â* and *yāda'* as parallel, both tantamount to "look with concern" (cf. Isa. lviii 3; Ps. xxxi 8) (Thomas [n. 47]). And, while esthetic evidence is inadmissible in the Court of Lower Criticism, I find the MT more satisfying in its ominous abruptness than the prosaic "and God revealed himself to them". In the MT, the four *'ēlōhîms* fall like hammer blows, accompanied by alternating verbs of perception and cognition: "heard . . . remembered . . . saw . . . knew".⁴⁹

There is yet another consideration, interesting to observe, though unhelpful in choosing between the MT and LXX. If the MT "and God knew" is correct, vv. 23b-25 could have been inserted elsewhere—for example, after Exod. i 13, "And the Egyptians worked Israel's children harshly". This would have made more explicit the providence underlying the events of Exod. ii. If, however, the LXX is correct, then the Redactor could have placed vv. 23b-25 only before the Burning Bush scene, reminding the reader, in the midst of a pastoral interlude, that Israel's suffering continued. Even Pharaoh's death (Exod. ii 23a), which might have brought relief, changes nothing.⁵⁰

I have raised two questions: what is the original function of Exod. ii 23b-25, and what is the correct reading of v. 25? The answer to both can be found, I submit, in Ezek. xx 5-9:

⁵On the day of my choosing Israel, when I raised my arm to the seed of Jacob's house and made myself known to them (*wā'ūwāda' lāhem*) in the land of Egypt, I raised my arm to them, saying, "I am Yahweh your god". ⁶On that day I raised my arm to them, to take them out from the land of Egypt to the land I scouted out for them, flowing with milk and honey, the most beautiful of all lands. ⁷I said to them, "Each of you cast away the abominations of his eyes (i.e., seductive abominations), and do not pollute yourselves with the dunglings (i.e., gods) of Egypt. I am Yahweh your god". ⁸But they rebelled against me and would not heed me. Each

⁴⁸ Cf. C. Carniti, "*wajjēda' 'ēlōhîm* (Es. 2,25): 'e Dio li riconobbe?'" *Greg* 73 (1992), pp. 337-8.

⁴⁹ We can save the pattern of repeated *'ēlōhîms* and still emend the verb after the Greek. Schmidt (*Exodus 1* [Neukirchen-Vluyn, 1988], p. 79) reads **wayyūwāda' 'ēlōhîm* "and God made himself known," conflating the MT and LXX. This preserves the impressive repetition of *'ēlōhîm*, but is a reading unattested in any tradition. The Documentarian saves the repetition of *'ēlōhîm*, in any case, by observing that Exod. ii 25 originally flowed into vi 2-9. I.e., the series originally ended with *wayyō(?)mer 'ēlōhîm* (Exod. vi 2).

⁵⁰ Cf. R. Joseph Bekhor Shor, ad loc.

man did not cast away the abominations of his eyes, and they did not abandon the dunglings of Egypt. So I resolved to pour out my wrath upon them, spending my anger against them within the land of Egypt.⁹ But I acted for the sake of my name, lest it be profaned in the eyes of the nations in whose midst they were, to whom I had revealed myself (*nôda'tî 'ălêhem*) in their eyes, by taking them out from the land of Egypt.

The connections between the book of Ezekiel and the Priestly stratum, especially Lev. xvii-xxvi, are too numerous to list here.⁵¹ Explanations for the phenomenon vary: one author was influenced by the other, they shared a temporal and/or social milieu, they shared literary antecedents. That Ezek. xx in particular has contacts with P is well known; compare Ezek. xx 12, 16, 20 with Exod. xxxi 12-17 (the Sabbath); Ezek. xx 11, 13, 21 with Lev. xviii 5 (living by obedience to Yahweh).

Ezek. xx also has many contacts with Exod. vi 2-9.⁵² Ezek. xx 28 ("I brought them to the land which I raised my arm to give to them") evokes Exod. vi 8 ("I shall bring you to the land that I raised my arm to give to Abraham . . ."); Ezek. xx 33-5 ("As I live . . . with a strong hand and an extended arm . . . I shall take you out . . . with a strong hand and an extended arm . . . I will enter into judgement") recalls Exod. vi 6 ("I am Yahweh, I will bring you out . . . with an extended arm and with great judgements"); Ezek. xx 38 ("land of sojournings") echoes the same expression in Exod. vi 4 (also Gen. xvii 8, xxviii 4, xxxvi 7).

Commentators have noted particularly strong links between Ezek. xx 5-9 and Exod. vi 2-9.⁵³ Compare the use of the verb *hōšî* "take out" in Ezek. xx 6, 9 (also *v.* 10) and Exod. vi 6, 7, and likewise the expression *nāšā(ʿ) yād* "to lift the arm" in Ezek. xxix 5, 6 (also *vv.* 15, 23, 28, 42) and Exod. vi 8.⁵⁴ In Ezek. xx 5 the Deity announces "I am Yahweh your God", as in Exod. vi 7 (compare also "I am Yahweh"

⁵¹ See M. Burrows, *The Literary Relations of Ezekiel* (Philadelphia, 1925), pp. 28-36, 47-68; W. Zimmerli, *Ezekiel 1* (Philadelphia, 1979), pp. 46-52 = *Ezechiel* (Neukirchen-Vluyn, 1969) pp. 70*-79*. On the general question of Ezekiel's literary sources, see also M. Greenberg, "Notes on the Influence of Tradition on Ezekiel", *JANES* 22 (1993), pp. 29-37. The question of the separate origin of Lev. xvii-xxvi, the so-called "Holiness Code", will not be considered here.

⁵² See W. Eichrodt, *Ezekiel* (London and Philadelphia, 1970) = *Der Prophet Hesekiel* (Göttingen, 1959, 1966); Friedman (n. 12), p. 63; Zimmerli (n. 51), pp. 407-8 = German, pp. 443-4; M. Greenberg, *Ezekiel 1-20* (Garden City, New York, 1983), pp. 363-4.

⁵³ See J.L. Ska, "La place d'Ex. 6, 2-8 dans la narration de l'Exode", *ZAW* 94 (1982), p. 539.

⁵⁴ Yahweh otherwise lifts his arm to swear only in Num. xiv 30 (P); Deut. xxxii 40; Ezek. xxxvi 7, xlv 12, xlvii 14; Neh. ix 15.

in Exod. vi 2, 8).⁵⁵ In fact, these are the only two biblical texts mentioning God's self-revelation in Egypt. We should note, too, the similarity of Ezek. xx 5, 9 (*wā'iwwāda'*, *nōda'tî* "I made myself known") and Exod. vi 2 (*nōda'tî* "I was [not] known"). Pervading both Ezek. xx and Exod. vi 2-9 is the theme of God making known his name—which can mean both publishing his fame, and revealing his personal name Yahweh.⁵⁶

What I believe has escaped notice is that Ezek. xx 5 resembles Exod. ii 25 as well as Exod. vi 2-9—and in the LXX form. That is, *wā'iwwāda' lāhem* "I made myself known to them" (Ezek. xx 5) corresponds to **wayyiwwāda' 'ālêhem* (Exod. ii 25 [LXX *Vorlage*]); compare also *nōda'tî 'ālêhem* (Ezek. xx 9) and *nōda'tî lāhêm* (Exod. vi 2).

If we adopt the LXX of Exod. ii 25, we must account for the corruption of the MT. Exod. ii 23b-25, in the composite Torah, introduces the non-Priestly Burning Bush scene (Exod. iii-iv), wherein we read, "I have beheld the oppression of my people in Egypt, and I have heard their scream before their overseers; I *know* (*yāda'tî*) their pains" (Exod. iii 7). The copyist, aware of what was ahead, may have anticipated the Qal of *yāda'*, substituting it in Exod. ii 25 for the rarer Niphal. The other corruption, the change of **'ālêhem* to *'ēlōhîm*, was conditioned by the immediate context, in which the divine title appears three times already. Most likely the two changes were simultaneous—unless Schmidt is correct, and the original was **wayyiwwāda' 'ēlōhîm* (see n. 49). In any case, whether Ezekiel is copying P or P copying Ezekiel, or even if the two share a common source, Ezek. xx 5 appears to establish the correct text of Exod. ii 25.⁵⁷

Ezek. xx 5 potentially does more. It suggests that Exod. ii 23b-25 was not created to set up the Burning Bush scene, but originally flowed

⁵⁵ This common Priestly cliché reinforces an oath or command (Exod. vi 7; xvi 12, xxix 46; Lev. xi 44, xviii 2, 4, 30, xix 2, 3, 4, 10, 25, 31, 34, 36, xx 7, 24, xxiii 22, 43, xxiv 22, xxv 17, 38, 55, xxvi 1, 13; Num. x 10, xv 41; also Judg. vi 10; Ezek. xx 5, 7, 19, 20). A study of the expression is W. Zimmerli, "Ich bin Yahweh", in *Geschichte und Altes Testament* (Fs. A. Alt) (Tübingen, 1953), pp. 179-209.

⁵⁶ A further parallel is problematic. If we follow the MT of Ezek. xx 6, reading *tartî* "I scouted out", then we should note that *twr* is Priestly vocabulary (Num. xiii 2, 16, 21, 25, 32, xiv 6, 7, 34, 36, 38), although absent in Exod. vi. If, however, we read **nātattî* in Ezek. xx 6, following the Syriac and Targum and matching Exod. xx 15, then the idea of Yahweh "giving" the land is paralleled in Exod. vi 4, 8 (*lātēt, wēnātattî*), in close proximity to raising the arm in oath. Zimmerli upholds the difficult MT of Ezek. xx 6, probably rightly ([n. 51] p. 400 = German, p. 435).

⁵⁷ One might object that knowing Yahweh is a common biblical theme that could appear independently in P and Ezekiel. But statements that Yahweh is known, or makes himself known (Niphal of *yāda'*) are surprisingly rare, limited to Exod. ii 25 (LXX), vi 3; Isa. xix 21; Ezek. xx 5, xxxv 11, xxxviii 23; Ps. ix 17, xlviii 4, lxxvi 2; cf. Isa. lxvi 14.

into Exod. vi 2. In other words, P (or some part of it) was originally an independent narrative source.⁵⁸

This argument is most cogent under the assumption that Ezekiel is paraphrasing P.⁵⁹ A. Hurvitz's celebrated study has shown the linguistic priority of P,⁶⁰ and it is likely that Ezekiel's senior contemporary Jeremiah also knew P, or one of P's sources, since Jer. iv 23 ostensibly alludes to Gen. i.⁶¹ If, despite the linguistic evidence, Ezekiel is earlier than P,⁶² matters are less clear. That is, if Exod. ii 25, vi 2 (P) quotes Ezek. xx 5, we cannot exclude the possibility that a Priestly supplementer broke apart a prophetic oracle to create a framework for the non-P narrative.⁶³ But the simpler scenario would posit a continuous P text based upon Ezekiel. Simplest of all is the thesis from which we started, that Ezekiel derives from P.⁶⁴

There are, of course, glaring differences between P and Ezek. xx. Ezekiel ignores Moses and Aaron, the Plagues, the Passover and the Sea. P contains no episode of idolatry and punishment in Egypt, though

⁵⁸ For the argument of Burrows (n. 51), p. 67 that four passages indicate that the book of Ezekiel is based on the *composite* Torah, see Appendix 2 at the end of the present article.

⁵⁹ See, among others, Burrows (n. 51); H. Haag, *Was lehrt die literarische Untersuchung des Ezechiel-Textes?* (Freiburg [Schweiz], 1943); M. Haran, *Temples and Temple Service in Ancient Israel* (Oxford, 1978); Friedman, *Exile and Biblical Narrative*, pp. 61-4. J. Milgrom's forthcoming volume on Leviticus xvii-xxvii (*Anchor Bible*) will also defend the priority of P. Burrows shows that Ezekiel's quotations of older literature are imprecise, and Greenberg (n. 51) similarly argues that it was the prophet's practice to transform tradition radically. Perhaps, as Burrows suggests, Ezekiel quoted from memory.

⁶⁰ *A Linguistic Study of the Relationship between the Priestly Source and the Book of Ezekiel* (Paris, 1982). See also R. Polzin, *Late Biblical Hebrew* (Decatur, 1976), and M.F. Rooker, "Ezekiel and the Typology of Biblical Hebrew", *HAR* 12 (1990), pp. 133-55. These studies deal primarily with relative dating. Current proposals for absolute date range from Solomonic (Knohl) to Hezekian (Haran, Friedman) to Exilic (Cross) to post-Exilic (the majority since Wellhausen), some of the disagreement arising from differing delineations of P. I decline to assign and defend an absolute date to P in this article, given the complexities of the issue and constraints of space.

⁶¹ See, e.g., Friedman (n. 12), pp. 72-3. For the contrary view, that Jer. iv 23 is a late, post-P addition to Jeremiah, see A. Borges de Sousa, "Jer. 4, 23-26 als P-orientierter Abschnitt", *ZAW* 105 (1993), pp. 419-28. Friedman also, plausibly, detects influence from Gen. i in Jer. iii 16-17. On the many contacts between Jeremiah and the Pentateuchal tradition see W.L. Holladay, *Jeremiah 2* (Minneapolis, 1989), pp. 36-9.

⁶² So, recently, Blum (n. 4), p. 237.

⁶³ Cf. Lohfink's analysis of the relationship between Num. xiii 32, xiv 36-7 (P) and Ezek. xxxvi 3, 13 ([n. 3] p. 212).

⁶⁴ We also cannot exclude the possibility of a common source, whatever the chronological order of P and Ezekiel. My sole claim is that there was *some* Priestly narrative source behind the stratum we designate P, however much it may have been reworded and supplemented before, during or after combination with non-P.

it does mention the punishment of the gods of Egypt (Exod. xii 12; cf. Josh. xxiv 14). Ezek. xx 5 speaks of the election (*bḥr*) of Israel, a Deuteronomic (Deut. vii 6-8, x 15, xiv 2) concept favored by Second Isaiah (Isa. xl 8-9, xliii 10, xliv 1-2) but absent from P, which knows only the election of Aaron (Num. xvi 5, 7, xvii 20).⁶⁵ Ezek. xx 6, 15 speaks of the "land flowing with milk and honey", an expression prominent in all the Pentateuchal sources *except* P, wherein it appears only in Lev. xx 24.⁶⁶

An oft-noted difference between P and Ezekiel is the prophet's non-mention of the covenant with the Patriarchs. Some take Ezek. xx 5 to say that Yahweh's first covenant was with the Exodus generation,⁶⁷ arguing that the theme of the Patriarchal covenant was a late development in Israelite tradition.⁶⁸ I think this is a misinterpretation. Ezek. xxxiii 24 refers to Abraham's inheritance of the land, elsewhere a reward for covenant fidelity (e.g., Gen. xv, xvii, etc.). Ezek. xxviii 25 mentions "my servant, Jacob", and Ezek. xxxvii 25 makes parallel "my servant, Jacob" and "my servant, David", before envisioning a new covenant with all Israel. The conjunction implies that Yahweh's relationship with Jacob the individual, as with David, was covenantal. Thus, Ezek. xx 5 probably does not mean that Yahweh's first covenant was with Israel in Egypt. Rather, the prophet, throughout his book, shares the common biblical theme of successive covenants. The election of the Hebrew slaves does not preclude a covenant with their ancestors.⁶⁹

⁶⁵ See K. Koch, "Zur Geschichte der Erwählungsvorstellung in Israel", *ZAW* 67 (1955/6), pp. 205-26.

⁶⁶ Many consider the expression a Deuteronomistic interpolation wherever it appears (Exod. iii 8, 17, xiii 5, xxxiii 3; Lev. xx 24; Num. xiii 27, xiv 8, xvi 13, 14; Deut. vi 3, xi 9, xxvi 9, 15, xxvii 3, xxxi 20; Josh. v 6; Jer. xi 5, xxxii 22; Ezek. xx 6, 15). I think this is far from clear. It may well have been a popular cliché.

⁶⁷ All biblical entities and persons described as "chosen" (*bḥr*)—Israel, David, Aaron, Levi—are also said to have a covenant with Yahweh. It is a reasonable inference, then, that Ezek. xx 5-9 speaks of a national covenant, even if the term *bērît* is not used. Ezekiel alludes to the covenant between Yahweh and Israel in chapter 16, comparing it to a marriage.

⁶⁸ E.g., J. Van Seters, "Confessional reformulation in the exilic period", *VT* 22 (1972), pp. 448-59; idem, *Prologue to History: the Yahwist as Historian in Genesis* (Louisville, 1992), pp. 215-76; T. Römer, *Israels Väter* (Freiburg [Schweiz] and Göttingen, 1990). See also the response to Römer by Lohfink, *Die Väter Israels im Deuteronomium* (Freiburg [Schweiz] and Göttingen, 1991).

⁶⁹ An instructive parallel is Lev. xxvi 45. Read alone, the verse might also imply that Yahweh's first covenant (*bērît rî[']šōnîm*) was with the Exodus generation. But v. 42 mentions the covenant with Jacob, Isaac and Abraham. Van Seters resolves the contradiction by excising the latter two patriarchs from v. 42, and taking the remaining "Jacob"

But why not at least mention the earlier covenant? Because in chapter xx the prophet is harranguing his audience, not impartially surveying history.⁷⁰ The backsliding Hebrews of the Exodus were an excellent paradigm for the prophet's contemporaries. The faithful Patriarchs were not.

Have I recovered the intact Priestly Source and thereby proven part of the Documentary Hypothesis? Not really. Because my evidence is a disputed reading, the analysis has both the virtue (internal consistency) and liability (untestability) of any circular argument. The case for P as independent source must continue to rest primarily on the arguments advanced in the first part of this essay.

Still, if we accept the association of Exod. ii 25, vi 2 and Ezek. xx 5, we find further evidence that P is not just a series of supplements written into the non-Priestly text. Rather, a Redactor combined non-P with pre-existing Priestly versions of the Creation, the Flood, the Patriarchs, the Liberation from Egypt, Sinai, the Tabernacle and Israel's adventures in the wilderness and most likely the Settlement, in addition to genealogies and miscellaneous cultic, ethical and legal materials. While we cannot absolutely prove that these formed a continuous document,⁷¹ ideological, linguistic, stylistic and thematic consistency, along with internal cross references, narrative flow and a sense of overall structure, suggest there really was a Priestly narrative document.⁷² But until it is truly recovered intact, we shall not know for sure.⁷³

as the nation, not the man ("The So-Called Deuteronomistic Redaction of the Pentateuch", in J.A. Emerton [ed.], *Congress Volume: Leuven 1989*, SVT 43 [Leiden, 1992], p. 67). Before such drastic surgery, we would do better to consider the polyvalence of the conjunction/relative pronoun 'āšer. We could translate Lev. xxvi 45 in one of two ways, either of which eliminates the contradiction with v. 42: (a) "I will remember their first covenant *as when* I took them out from the land of Egypt . . ." (b) "I *who* took them out from the land of Egypt will remember their first covenant . . ." Either seems preferable to conjectural emendation.

⁷⁰ So Greenberg (n. 52), p. 364. This raises the question of whether Ezekiel is a reliable witness to historical traditions and texts. Not always, but in the case of Ezek. xx 5 and Exod. ii 25, vi 2 I find the similarities so striking as to outweigh doubts. See also Greenberg (n. 51).

⁷¹ See the cautious remarks of Friedman (n. 12), pp. 80, 91, 95, 118-19.

⁷² On P's main ideas see Friedman (n. 3), pp. 188-206. On P's vocabulary, see (provisionally) S.R. Driver, *An Introduction to the Literature of the Old Testament* (Edinburgh, 1891), pp. 133-4. On P's style see S.E. McEvenue, *The Narrative Style of the Priestly Writer* (Rome, 1971) and M. Paran, *Forms of the Priestly Style in the Pentateuch* (Hebrew) (Jerusalem, 1989). On P's overall structure, see Blenkinsopp, "The Structure of P", *CBQ* 38 (1976), pp. 275-92.

⁷³ My thanks to Richard Elliott Friedman, David Noel Freedman and other colleagues and students at the University of California, San Diego, for their comments on various drafts of this article.

Appendix 1: passages to be assigned to P

I provisionally assign the following passages to the Priestly stratum of the Torah: Gen. i 1-ii 3, vi 9-22, vii 8-9, 11, 13-16a, 21, 24, viii 1-2a, 3b-5, 7, 13a, 14-19, ix 1-17, x 1b-7, 20, 22-3, 31, 32, xi 27b-31, xii 4b-5, xiii 6, 11b-12a, xvi 3, 15-16, xvii 1-27, xix 29, xxi 1b, 2b-5, xxiii 1-20, xxv 7-11a, 13-18, 20, xxvi 34-5, xxvii 46, xxviii 1-9, xxxi 18b, xxxv 9-15, 23-9, xxxvii 1, xli 45b-46a, xlv 6-27, xlvii 27b-28, xlviii 3-6, xlix 29-33, l 12-13; Exod. i 7, 13-14, ii 23b-25, vi 2-12, vii 1-13, 19-20a, 21b-22, viii 1-3, 11b-15, ix 8-12, xii 1-20, 28, 40-1, 43-51, xiii 1-2, xiv 1-4, 8-9, 15-18, 21a, 21c-23, 26-27a, 28a, 29, xvi 2-3, 6-35a, 36, xix 1, xxiv 15b-18, xxv 1-xxxii 18, xxxiv 29-35, xxxv-xl; Lev. i 1-xxiii 38, xxiv 1-xxvi 38, 46, xxvii 1-34; Num. i 1-ii 34, iii 2-ix 14, x 1-12, 14-27, xiii 1-16, 21, 25-6, 32, xiv 1a 2-3, 5-10, 26-39, xv 32-41, xvi 1a, 2b-11, 15-24, 27a, 32b, 35, xvii 1-xviii 32, xix 1-22, xx 1b-13, 23-9, xxv 6-19, xxvi 1-8, 12-65, xxvii 1-23, xxx 1-17, xxxi 1-54, xxxii 1-42, xxxiii 50-6, xxxiv 1-29, xxxv 1-39, xxxvi 1-13; Deut. xxxiv 7-9. Further study might detect various strata within this material (e.g., the problematic H stratum), but at present I am concerned only with P narrative. I agree with Blenkinsopp, Lohfink, Friedman, etc., that there is some P in Joshua (e.g., Josh. xviii 1), but would not be more specific at this point.

Appendix 2 (see n. 58 above)

Burrows (n. 51 above), p. 67, cites four passages indicating that the book of Ezekiel (which, following C.C. Torrey, he dates to late pre-Hasmonean times) is based on the *composite* Torah. We must examine this claim in detail, as it is directly counter to the thrust of my argument.

First, Burrows asserts (pp. 55-6) that Ezekiel quotes both the J and P Flood narratives, vaguely commenting that “a list of creatures like those in [Ezekiel] chapter 1 appears in Gn. 6:7”. But I find no similarity to Ezek. i at all in Gen. vi 7, and do not understand Burrows’s point.

Second, Burrows notes (pp. 51-2) that, of forty-one countries named in Ezek. xxvii, between fifteen and twenty-one (depending on emendations) are found in the Priestly sections of Gen. x, while four or five more are shared with the Yahwistic verses of Gen. x. Because Burrows does not present a source partition of Gen. x or specify the toponymns, no direct response is possible. However, given that Gen. x and Ezek. xxvii are listing nations that existed for centuries, some overlap between

Ezekiel and J is to be expected; indeed, we would expect more than five examples.

Third, Burrows observes (p. 67) that, while Ezek. xx 5-6 in general recalls Exod. vi 2-8 (P), Ezek. xx 6 also borrows the expression "a land flowing with milk and honey" (Exod. iii 8, 17) from the non-Priestly Burning Bush scene. This is a better argument, but it still remains possible either that the expression was simply proverbial (cf. Burrows p. 3; n. 66 above), or that Ezekiel drew upon and conflated the still unredacted non-P and P, thus anticipating the editing of the Torah.

Burrows's fourth and best argument (pp. 10, 57-8, 67) is that Ezekiel's vision of Yahweh's theophany draws upon both the Priestly and non-Priestly portions of Exod. xxiv. On the one hand, both Ezekiel and non-P describe the "God of Israel" (Ezek. viii 4, ix 3; cf. Exod. xxiv 10 [non-P]) enthroned over "sapphire" (Ezek. i 26; cf. Exod. xxiv 10 [non-P]); on the other hand, Ezekiel calls the divine presence "the Glory" (*kābôd*), a typical P-word used in Exod. xxiv 17 (P) and elsewhere. This argument, however, is ultimately inconclusive. Because *kābôd* is as characteristic of Ezekiel as of P (Ezek. i 28, iii 12, 23, viii 4, ix 3, x 4, 18, 19, xi 22, 23, xxxix 21, xliii 2, 4, 5, xlv 4), the prophet may rather be recounting the non-Priestly Sinai tradition in his own words. Or, again, he may know non-P and P as parallel, independent documents.

In short, that Ezekiel knew both P and non-P I do not doubt. But it is almost impossible to prove he knew them in redacted form. How would Burrows explain the connection between Ezek. xx 5 and Exod. ii 25, vi 2 treated here? The most I would grant is that Ezekiel may have known both the composite Torah and the separate P and non-P sources.